

Kris Shuman

Professor Miller

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**Starved, Forgotten, and Discarded: Joseph Plumb Martin's View of the Continental
Army**

Joseph Plumb Martin's *Narrative of a Revolutionary Soldier* presents the Revolutionary War as far more difficult and disorganized than many patriotic accounts suggest. Throughout the memoir, Martin repeatedly criticizes the inadequate food, supplies, and treatment provided to the Continental Army. While some suffering was unavoidable during wartime, Martin's assessment was largely correct because the shortages and neglect he describes appear consistently throughout his account rather than as isolated incidents. His descriptions of starvation, lack of clothing and supplies, broken promises from the government, and poor treatment of soldiers show that many members of the Continental Army endured extreme hardship during the Revolution.

One of Martin's strongest criticisms involves the lack of food provided to soldiers. He repeatedly describes severe hunger and starvation throughout the memoir (Martin 110). At one point, Martin states, "We were absolutely, literally starved" and explains that he survived four days without food except for "a little black birch bark" that he chewed from a stick of wood (Martin 110). This passage shows that soldiers were experiencing far more than ordinary discomfort. Going several days without food demonstrates a major failure in the army's ability to supply its men. Martin also presents starvation as a recurring issue instead of a single terrible moment. During the Yorktown campaign, he describes seeing formerly enslaved people who had

followed Cornwallis “dead and dying” from starvation with burned corn still in their hands and mouths (Martin 153). Although this example involves civilians rather than Continental soldiers, it reinforces Martin’s larger point about the widespread lack of food and suffering connected to the war. These repeated examples make Martin’s criticism believable because they show a continuing pattern of hunger and deprivation throughout the conflict.

Food shortages were not the only hardship Martin described. He also repeatedly criticizes the lack of clothing and basic supplies provided to soldiers throughout the war (Martin 33). In one passage, he explains that starvation eventually became secondary because “hard duty and nakedness were considered the prime evils” after soldiers lost their clothing during the Kipp’s Bay affair (Martin 33). This statement reveals how severe conditions had become. Soldiers were expected to continue marching and fighting while lacking proper clothing and protection from the weather. Martin often describes men sleeping outside in miserable conditions with little shelter or comfort (Martin 33). These hardships were not simply caused by the enemy or the battlefield but by failures within the military supply system itself. By repeatedly returning to the subjects of nakedness, exposure, and exhaustion, Martin suggests that the army consistently failed to meet even the most basic needs of its soldiers. His descriptions make it difficult to dismiss his complaints as exaggerations caused by temporary frustration.

Beyond food and supplies, Martin also criticizes how soldiers were treated and respected by political leaders and the government. He believed many promises made to soldiers were either ignored or forgotten after the war ended (Martin 181). Martin writes that soldiers who enlisted for the war were promised land, but after their service they were “turned adrift like old worn out horses” with “nothing said about land to pasture them upon” (Martin 181). This comparison shows Martin’s bitterness toward leaders who benefited from soldiers’ sacrifices while failing to

properly reward them afterward. Martin believed soldiers gave years of service and endured terrible hardships only to be discarded once they were no longer useful. His criticism goes beyond physical suffering and focuses on what he saw as moral neglect. This passage strengthens his overall argument because it shows that his frustration was not limited to battlefield conditions alone. Instead, he believed the government repeatedly failed to respect the men who fought for American independence.

Martin's descriptions also suggest that many soldiers felt powerless and ignored during the war itself. Throughout the memoir, he often portrays ordinary soldiers as men who were expected to suffer quietly while political and military leaders failed to understand their conditions (Martin 110). Even when soldiers endured starvation, exposure, and exhaustion, Martin rarely describes leaders successfully solving these problems. Instead, hardship became something soldiers simply learned to survive. His memoir presents common soldiers as the people carrying the burden of the Revolution while receiving little recognition in return. This continued frustration helps explain why Martin's account is often critical in tone. He was not simply remembering isolated bad experiences many years later. He believed the suffering of ordinary soldiers reflected deeper failures within the Continental Army and the government supporting it.

Another major source of frustration for Martin was the constant uncertainty surrounding pay and compensation. Soldiers often served for long periods without receiving the money they had been promised, which damaged morale throughout the army. Martin repeatedly suggests that common soldiers were expected to sacrifice endlessly while receiving very little in return for their service. Even when soldiers remained loyal to the cause of independence, many believed the government treated them as disposable once their labor and military service had been

exhausted. Martin's complaints about pay were connected to his larger criticism of leadership because he believed political leaders praised soldiers publicly while failing to properly support them materially. This pattern reinforced his belief that the suffering of the Continental Army was not caused only by war itself, but also by failures from those responsible for organizing and supporting the army. His repeated frustrations about compensation strengthen the argument that his criticism reflected long-term problems rather than isolated emotional reactions.

Martin also describes how harsh conditions affected soldiers emotionally and mentally throughout the war. Constant hunger, exposure, exhaustion, and uncertainty created an atmosphere where survival often became more important than patriotism or military glory. Unlike romanticized accounts of the Revolution, Martin's memoir focuses heavily on ordinary suffering and daily hardship rather than heroic battlefield victories. His writing often portrays soldiers as exhausted men struggling simply to continue marching and surviving from one day to the next. This perspective is important because it presents the Revolution from the viewpoint of ordinary enlisted soldiers rather than famous political or military leaders. Martin's account suggests that many soldiers experienced the war not as a glorious struggle for liberty but as a prolonged period of deprivation and sacrifice. By emphasizing these daily hardships throughout the memoir, Martin reinforces the credibility of his criticisms and demonstrates that poor conditions shaped nearly every aspect of a soldier's experience in the Continental Army.

Martin also criticizes the inconsistency and disorganization that seemed to define much of the Continental Army's operations. Throughout the memoir, soldiers were frequently moved from place to place while still lacking dependable food, clothing, or pay. Martin often describes long marches and exhausting labor that produced very little improvement in conditions for ordinary soldiers. This constant uncertainty added to the frustration many soldiers felt because

they were expected to continue obeying orders and risking their lives while basic necessities remained unavailable. Martin's descriptions suggest that many soldiers gradually lost confidence in the ability of military and political leaders to properly manage the war effort. Even though many soldiers remained committed to independence, Martin portrays daily military life as chaotic and poorly organized rather than disciplined and efficient. His memoir repeatedly focuses on confusion, shortages, exhaustion, and broken systems, reinforcing his larger argument that the suffering experienced by soldiers was rooted in larger structural failures within the Continental Army itself.

At the same time, some of the hardships Martin describes were probably unavoidable. The Continental Army was fighting a long war against a powerful enemy, and the young United States lacked money, strong central authority, and reliable transportation systems. Under the Articles of Confederation, Congress struggled to consistently fund and supply the army. Wartime shortages affected many people during the Revolution, not just soldiers. However, Martin's memoir remains convincing because the problems he describes appear constantly throughout the narrative and across many years of service (Martin 33; Martin 110; Martin 181). His complaints involve multiple types of hardship, including food shortages, lack of clothing, poor living conditions, and broken promises after the war. The consistency of these examples makes it difficult to argue that Martin's view was distorted only by a handful of bad experiences. If Martin only described one or two incidents, his criticism might appear exaggerated or emotional. Instead, the memoir presents hardship as a constant feature of military life throughout the Revolution.

Overall, Joseph Plumb Martin's criticism of the Continental Army was largely justified. His memoir presents repeated evidence of starvation, inadequate supplies, broken promises, poor

compensation, and neglect by military and political leaders. While some suffering was unavoidable during the Revolutionary War, Martin demonstrates that these problems became normal conditions for many soldiers rather than isolated incidents. His account provides a far less romantic view of the Revolution and reveals the extreme sacrifices made by ordinary soldiers who often fought without proper support from the country they helped create. Rather than presenting the war as a story of constant heroism and victory, Martin's memoir focuses on the daily realities faced by common soldiers. Because these hardships appear repeatedly throughout his narrative, his criticism of the Continental Army ultimately appears far more credible than exaggerated.

Works Cited

Martin, Joseph Plumb. *Narrative of a Revolutionary Soldier*. Signet Classics, 2001.